

A NITI Aayog report lists the strategies that made India a self-reliant country such as focused drive to raise productions, quality seeds, price support and protective tariffs. It advises re-learning the “lessons from the past strategies” and “area retention” to prevent farmers from shifting to crops like wheat, paddy and sugarcane which give assured incomes to them through open-ended procurements. India declares minimum support price for 23 crops but only wheat, paddy and sugarcane, are effectively procured.

Trade and agriculture expert Biswajit Dhar explains, “The post-liberalisation withdrawal of the government from the economy, particularly in agriculture, contributed to import dependence. A piecemeal approach or quick fixes, instead of holistic agricultural policy, caused this anomaly of huge surpluses in some (wheat, paddy and sugarcane) and huge shortages in others (edible oils and pulses).”

ANOTHER DIMENSION

The Economic Survey 2025-26 notes that recent incentives for ethanol blending, particularly for the promotion of maize-to-ethanol, have distorted input and output markets, driving more farmers away from edible oils, pulses and cereals like millets and shifting towards maize cultivation. Also, the expected reduction in paddy acreage has not happened. These crops compete “for land, water and labour.” It flags risks of entrenched import dependence and vulnerabilities in food and nutrition securities if the distortions are not corrected.

Ramanjaneyulu GV, the executive director of the Centre for Sustainable Agriculture, who was part of the Technology Mission on

TURNING THE TIDE

▶ Self-reliant in oilseeds and pulses in 1980s-90s; minimal chemical fertiliser imports before mid-1960s

▶ Incentives for ethanol blending driving farmers away from oilseeds and pulses to maize

▶ Key to self-reliance in oilseeds and pulses: area retention, quality seeds, effective procurement

▶ Fertiliser security through alternatives, diverse import sources, DBT to farmers instead of industry



PHOTO BY RAJWANT RAWAT

FOOD AND NUTRITIONAL SECURITY REALITY

▶ India ranks 102 out of 123 countries in the Global Hunger Index of 2025, below Rwanda, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, and Nepal

▶ Malnutrition in children under five years is high: stunting at 29.3%, wasting (too low a weight for one's height) at 19% and under-weight at 31.8%,

says the National Family Health Survey data

▶ India has the maximum number of multi-dimensionally poor at 231 million, as per UN-DP's Global Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI) 2023

▶ 813.5 million Indians are provided “free” monthly ration since April 2020

SOURCE GLOBAL HUNGER INDEX OF 2025, NFHS-6 DATA OF 2023-24, UNDP'S GLOBAL MULTIDIMENSIONAL POVERTY INDEX (MPI), 2023 AND MINISTRY OF CONSUMER AFFAIRS, FOOD & PUBLIC DISTRIBUTION